

Test drive day — 12 Sep 2026

Change the plan first

The original plan was Tesla plus Mazda CX-5. Research says change it.

Drop the CX-5 to second priority. The 2026 CX-5 is a first-year redesign. Consumer Reports published "5 Reasons to Avoid the 2026 Mazda CX-5 Now" in June 2026. Car and Driver's long-term car still bricks its infotainment at 10,000 miles. Mazda fell hard in the latest Consumer Reports reliability report.

Recommended order for the day:

Priority	Car	Why
1	Toyota RAV4 Hybrid or PHEV	Toyota leads reliability. The PHEV suits your charging situation
2	Tesla Model Y	Tesla rose in the reliability ranking. Confirm the charging plan works
3	Honda CR-V Hybrid	Car and Driver 10Best 2026. No first-year risk
4	Mazda CX-50	The mature Mazda. Uses the RAV4 hybrid powertrain
5	Mazda CX-5	Drive it to confirm or reject the reported faults

If you only get three drives, do 1, 2, and 3.

Rules for the day

1. **Do not negotiate.** Say "I am only driving today."
2. **Do not let anyone run your credit.** This costs you nothing to refuse.
3. **Do not sign anything.**
4. Ask for the out-the-door quote **by email** instead. That gives you a written number you can compare and forward.
5. Ask for **45 minutes** per car. Ten minutes tells you nothing.

Bring these

Item	What it tests
A car seat, borrowed if needed	Rear-facing fit behind your own driving position
A stroller	Whether it goes in the boot without folding the seats
Your largest suitcase	Real cargo space, not the brochure number
Your phone and cable	CarPlay or Android Auto pairing, and cable routing

Item	What it tests
Your sunglasses	Screen glare and reflections

Drive the same route in every car

Pick one loop and repeat it. Comparison only works if the route is constant.

The loop must include:

- A **highway on-ramp merge**. Accelerate hard. Judge whether it feels safe with four people aboard.
- A **rough or broken road**. Judge ride comfort and cabin noise.
- A **tight parking spot**. Reverse in. Use the camera.
- A **U-turn** or tight car park. Judge the turning circle.
- **Stop-and-go traffic** if you can find it.

Check in every car

Space, for the kid question

- Sit in the **back seat behind your own driving position**. Set the driver's seat where you actually drive, then get in behind it.
- Fit the car seat. Note whether you must move the front seat forward.
- Check the boot with the stroller **and** the suitcase in it at once.
- Check the rear door opening. A narrow opening makes loading a child hard.

Driving

- Visibility forward over the bonnet, and over your shoulder.
- Blind spots at the rear pillars.
- Seat comfort and whether the seat goes high enough.
- Cabin noise at 60 mph on coarse road surface.
- Brake feel.

Controls

- Can you adjust the climate without looking away from the road?
- Can you find the wipers, lights, and mirrors quickly?
- Does the screen accept touch **while moving**?
- Does CarPlay or Android Auto connect without fuss? Wired and wireless.

Car-specific things to test

Tesla Model Y

The charging plan is the real test, not the car.

- **Ask directly:** with no charger at home, and charging only at the office, what happens if the office chargers are full or you change jobs? Note the answer, then judge it yourself.
- There is **no instrument cluster**. All speed and gear information sits on the centre screen. Drive and decide whether that bothers you.
- The wipers and mirrors live in the touchscreen. Test the wipers. Bellevue is wet; this matters here more than most places.
- **Regenerative braking.** Lift off the accelerator and feel how hard it slows. Ask your wife to ride in the back for this. It causes motion sickness in some passengers.
- Ride firmness. Larger wheels ride harder.
- Test the phone-as-key. Then ask what happens when the phone battery dies.
- Ask what the warranty is. Compare it against the others.

Toyota RAV4 (2026, all new)

- It is **hybrid only** now. The petrol-only engines were dropped.
- Car and Driver criticised it: "interior materials feel cheap" and the "standard hybrid has a noisy engine." **Verify both yourself.** Accelerate hard and listen. Touch the dashboard and door plastics.
- If you drive the **PHEV**, confirm the electric range claim and ask how long a full charge takes on a normal office charger.
- This is also a first-year redesign. Ask the dealer whether they have seen any early problems.

Honda CR-V Hybrid

- It won Car and Driver 10Best for 2026, so expect competence, not excitement.
- Car and Driver's criticism of the **non-hybrid** is that the CVT drones under hard acceleration. Drive the **hybrid** and check whether it does the same.
- Check the boot. The CR-V is usually strong here.

Mazda CX-50

- The cabin is **tighter** than the CX-5 and the RAV4. The roof slopes. This is the car most likely to fail your rear-seat test. Test that first, before you fall for how it drives.
- The hybrid uses the **Toyota RAV4 hybrid system**. That is a point in its favour.

Mazda CX-5 (2026)

If you drive it, test the reported faults directly.

- **Sit with the infotainment for a full ten minutes.** Use CarPlay. Use the navigation. Switch sources. Restart the car and reconnect. The reported fault is intermittent freezing, so a short test

may miss it.

- Ask the salesperson, in these words: "Have any 2026 CX-5 customers come back with infotainment problems?" Watch the reaction as much as the answer.
- The **turbo engine is gone**. Only the naturally aspirated 2.5 remains, with a 6-speed automatic. Merge onto a motorway and judge whether it is enough.
- There is **no hybrid until 2027**.

Questions for the dealer

Ask these at every dealer. Write down the answers.

1. What is the out-the-door price on this exact car? Email it to me.
2. What is the destination charge, and what dealer fees do you add?
3. What add-ons are already on this car, and can they be removed?
4. What APR can I get, and at what credit tier? Is there a manufacturer subsidised rate?
5. Is there a manufacturer rebate or customer cash on this model right now?
6. Where was this specific car assembled? I want the VIN.
7. What does the scheduled maintenance cost for the first five years?
8. What is the warranty, in years and miles, for the powertrain and the battery?
9. Do you have this car in stock, or is it an order?

Note: Mazda advertised 0% for 36 months plus 90-day deferred payments, and \$1,000 customer cash on select 2026 CX-5 models. The CX-90 showed \$3,500 customer cash. Ask what applies to the exact car in front of you.

Score each car the same way

Fill this in for every car, on the day, before you leave the car park. Memory degrades fast when you drive several cars in a row.

Item	Score 1-5	Note
Rear seat behind my driving position		
Car seat fits		
Boot with stroller and suitcase		
Merging power		
Ride comfort on rough road		
Cabin noise at speed		
Visibility		
Controls without looking		

Item	Score 1-5	Note
Screen behaved		
Parking and turning circle		
Wife's verdict		
Would I keep this for 8 years		

Before you buy anything, later

Do not do these tomorrow. Do them before you commit.

1. **Get insurance quotes** for each car, by VIN or by trim. A Tesla usually costs more to insure. Get the real number for Bellevue, not an average.
2. **Confirm the office charging.** Which building, how many chargers, what cost, and what the queue is like at 09:00. Do this before you buy any EV.
3. **Get the out-the-door quote in writing** from every dealer, then compare.
4. **Get your own financing pre-approval** from a bank or credit union first. Then let the dealer try to beat it. Never take the first APR offered.
5. Check the annual Washington RTA excise tax on each car. It scales with the car's value and repeats every year.